pigeons. I didn't see any Pokémon, because I didn't have a smartphone. But Matan, looking around through his smartphone lens, could 'see' Pokémon standing on a rock or hiding behind a tree.

Though I couldn't see the creatures, they were obviously not confined to Matan's smartphone, because other people could 'see' them too. For example, we encountered two other kids who were hunting the same Pokémon. If Matan managed to capture a Pokémon, the other kids could immediately observe what happened. The Pokémon were inter-computer entities. They existed as bits in a computer network rather than as atoms in the physical world, but they could nevertheless interact with the physical world and influence it, as it were, in various ways.

Now let's examine a more consequential example of inter-computer realities. Consider the rank that a website gets in a Google search. When we google for news, flight tickets or restaurant recommendations, one website appears at the top of the first Google page, whereas another is relegated to the middle of the fiftieth page. What exactly is this Google rank, and how is it determined? The Google algorithm determines the website's Google rank by assigning points to various parameters, such as how many people visit the website and how many other websites link to it. The rank itself is an inter-computer reality, existing in a network connecting billions of computers – the internet. Like Pokémon, this inter-computer reality spills over into the physical world. For a news outlet, a travel agency or a restaurant it matters a great deal whether its website appears at the top of the first Google page or in the middle of the fiftieth page.[47]

Since the Google rank is so important, people use all kinds of tricks to manipulate the Google algorithm to give their website a higher rank. For example, they may use bots to generate more traffic to the website.[48] This is also a widespread phenomenon in social media, where coordinated bot armies are constantly manipulating the algorithms of YouTube, Facebook or X (formerly Twitter). If a post goes viral, is it because humans are really interested in it, or because thousands of bots managed to fool the algorithm?[49]

Inter-computer realities like Pokémon and Google ranks are analogous to intersubjective realities like the sanctity that humans ascribe to temples and cities. I lived much of my life in one of the holiest places on earth – the city of Jerusalem. Objectively, it is an ordinary place. As you walk around Jerusalem, you see houses, trees, rocks, cars, people, cats, dogs and